

PUMPKINS AND WINTER SQUASHES

Cucurbita maxima, *C. moschata* and *C. pepo*

Round, orange pumpkins are used as jack-o'-lanterns at Halloween, but they, and their close relatives winter squashes, are also found in a variety of unusual shapes, colors, and sizes. Delicious cooked, especially baked in pies, they store well, and are an excellent winter crop.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW/PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Pumpkins and winter squashes grow best in fertile, well-drained soil, in a sunny, open site. Since plants will spread and become quite large, plan carefully to allow them plenty of space; they will need about 3–5 ft (1–1.5 m) between plants. Sow seed under cover in mid-spring for planting out later.

CROP CARE

Seedlings should be planted out in deep, very fertile soil, once all risk of frost has passed.

Your crops will need slightly different care, depending on their growing habit. Trailing types can be trained up supports to keep them well-ventilated and off the ground, and to minimize



Plant seedlings in rich, well-mulched soil.

their growing space. Bear in mind that heavy fruits may need support with netting in the same way that melons do (see p.159). Mulch around the plants, and thin fruits to two or three per plant if you want large specimens.

Pumpkins and winter squashes need to be watered well, and benefit from regular supplementary feeding with a tomato fertilizer.